Chapter 9 - Ethics and Environment

Team 1

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Introduction

- Moral philosophy was focused mostly exclusively on humanity
  - Plato & Aristotle rooted moral philosophies in human properties:
    - Soul, Psyche, Reason
- Universal human rights grounded in rationality
- Even the Utilitarian (GHP) is confined to human beings
  - “Greatest happiness of the greatest number of people”

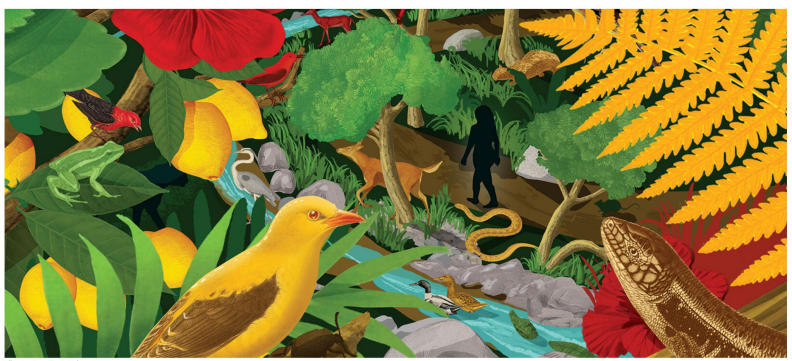


Illustration: Sam Falconer

“We are deeply interdependent on nature, and nature depends on us.”

- Nicole Heller (associate curator of Anthropocene studies for Carnegie Museum of Natural History)

Section 9.1 - Extending the Moral Sphere

- In late 18th century, moral concern began to extend beyond human beings
- Jeremy Bentham: (replaced reason with pleasure and pain)
- Insuperable: (of a difficulty or obstacle) impossible to overcome

> "What…should trace the insuperable line? Is it the faculty of reason or perhaps the faculty of discourse? But a full-grown horse or dog is beyond comparison a more rational, as well as a more conversable animal, than an infant of a day or a week or even a month, old."…But suppose the case were otherwise, what would it avail? The question is not, Can they reason?, nor Can they talk? But, Can they suffer?"
>
> (Bentham, 1789, 1960:283)

9.1 - Continued

- What makes infliction of unnecessary suffering objectionable, is the nature of suffering itself (pain, anxiety, distress)
  - So: Any being falls within this the scope of this principle
    - Applicable to animals with a certain kind of nervous system
- Widely accepted that animal suffering includes:
  - Mental suffering (fear and anxiety)
  - Physical suffering
- What about grief or embarrassment?
  - Tendency to anthropomorphize them (treat them as they were human)
- What counts as unnecessary suffering?
  - Production of human food, research aimed at benefiting human health, better cosmetic preparation, human entertainment, etc.?
- **"Morally speaking, animals matter, even if they do not matter as much as human beings"**

9.1 Continued

- Laika
  - Stray husky-spitz
  - First living creature to orbit the earth
  - Launched into space aboard Sputnik 2 (November 1957)
  - Given a compartment on the rocket with barely any space to move
  - Experienced rapid heart and breathing rates
  - Died soon after launch
- Tilikum
  - Captured when he was 2 years old off coast of Iceland
  - Killed three people including Seaworld trainer Dawn Brancheau in 2010

Animal Welfare vs. Rights

- Welfare means cannot be used for cruel acts - entertainment
  - Harsh circus treatment

- Can animals have the same rights as humans?
  - Rights != wellfare
  - Ch. 5 naturalism and virtue - lion in the zoo deteriorated physique and neurotic behavior

- Animals cannot decide their own rights with humans

The Humanity in Ethics

- Focuses on the ethical concern to ‘higher’, or quasi-human, beings
  - Ex. must have capacity to suffer or bearer of rights

- Environmental ethics
  - Human concerns must find significance in larger framework

Is environmental ethics still centered around humans?

Section 9.2: Pollution, Sustainability, and Climatic Change

- Like human rights, environmental values came to transcend differences between human groups (divided by religious and political beliefs)
- This happened through three major concerns (and relevant corresponding publications):
  - Pollution
  - Sustainability
  - Climatic Change

Pollution: “Silent Spring” (1962)

- By Rachel L. Carson, an American marine biologist and nature writer
- Empirical investigation into the costs and benefits of using synthetic chemicals in fertilizers and pesticides
- Title invokes a compelling image of a world in which birds no longer sang
  - Symbolized a destructive antagonism between economic interests and the natural world
- Ecology: scientific study of natural systems of biological interdependence
  - Rests upon the fundamental insight that the actions of individual human beings can have global consequences
- Made bestseller lists and was attacked by the chemical industry
  - Made “the environment” a topic of politically significance in a democratic culture committed to free speech and public debate
- Led to a nationwide ban on DDT and other pesticides
- Led to creation of US Environmental Protection Agency

“Silent Spring” in “The Three-Body Problem”

- A main character is given “Silent Spring” when in a reeducation camp during the Cultural Revolution in China
  - Is warned that this book is considered as a piece of capitalist propaganda
  - Shapes her view of humanity's destructiveness
  - Ye compares the industrial destruction described in the book with the violence of the Cultural Revolution

A scene from the TV show adaptation (2024)

Sustainability: “Limits to Growth” (1972)

- By Donella Meadows, Dennis Meadows, Jørgen Randers, and William W. Behrens III
  - Added global dimensions to topic of pollution/pesticides
  - Connecting to topics of economic degradation and climate change
- Environmental pollution isn’t the intentional outcome of individual actions, it is the unintentional outcome of general practices
- Environmental pollution can’t be assessed via ethical principles
  - Which aim to provide moral rules for individual human agents

“Limits to Growth”, cont.

- Modeled the consequences of an expanding human population committed to economic growth on the Earth's resources
- Five variables: world population, industrialization, pollution, food production, and resource depletion
    - As well as the ability of technology to increase resources
- Argued that sustainable use of natural resources would require population control and limits to economic growth
- Sustainability: introduced this term
    - Now commonly used to evaluate how human practices consume natural resources
    - Sustainable systems (fishing, farming, heating, etc.) don’t require major consumption of natural resources for their long-term maintenance
    - Sustainability might be a new, environmental value that generates responsibilities to a world wider than that of human beings and other sentient creatures

Climatic Change: IPCC's First Report (1990)

- Climatic Change/Global Warming: increase in the avg. temperature of the Earth's near-surface air and oceans
- Intergovernmental Panel on Climate change (IPCC), established by the World Meteorological Organization in 1988
  - First report published in 1990
- Concluded that there are substantial rises in avg. temperature, principally caused by carbon emissions generated by human activity
- Before this report, debate on global warming (and its causes) was largely confined to the scientific community
  - This report brought the debate to the general public

Climatic Change, cont.

- Global warming is relevant to moral philosophy because of two key features of environmentalism

1) Individual actions can cause ecological consequences (taking place within ecological systems that they may impact)
2) Ecological consequences have global significance

- Ex: my decision to operate a car can't be assessed only via costs/benefits of that decision to me, my family, or my society
  - Since I drive a car within an ecological system, the significance of that decision has to be assessed on a broader (e.g. global) context

Section 9.3

- “Our newly acquired understanding of ecology calls for a correspondingly new ethics”
  - Ecology changed how we see the world
  - Humans are part of complex ecosystems
  - If our understanding of nature changed, maybe our moral system should also change.
- Aldo Leopold
  - Professor in Agricultural Economics
  - Published “A Sand County Almanac”
    - 3 parts: “The Land Ethic”, “Wilderness”, and “Conservation Esthetic”

Section 9.3

- "The Land Ethic"
  - "A land ethic changes the role of Homo sapiens from conqueror of the land-community to plain member and citizen of it"
  - The idea of right and wrong defined through "integrity, stability, and beauty of the biotic community"
    - "Biotic community": entire ecosystem living together, humans are members, not masters
    - Integrity and stability are defined as wholeness of the system and sustenance over time
    - Actions that would push ecosystems to collapse are morally wrong
- Switch to the belief that ecosystem itself has moral standing

Consensus 5: *Tech Isn't Neutral*

- Technology is not neutral → it reflects human subjectivity
- If we treat tech as legitimate without questioning it, autonomy shrinks!

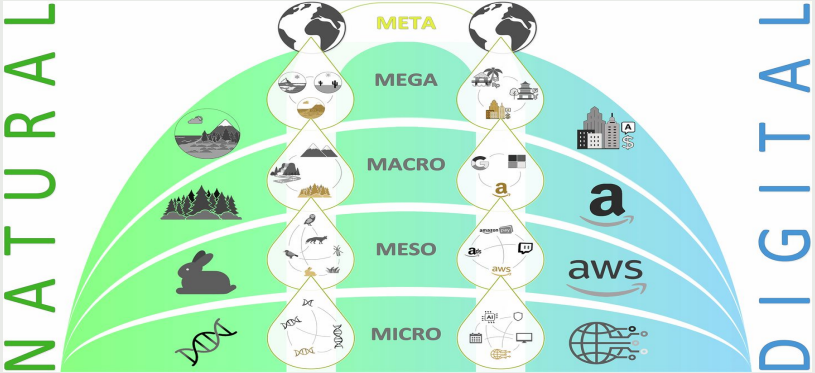
"Privacy is not limited to intrusive surveillance, it is the foundation of a safe personal space to incubate diversity and growth, void of criticism, judgment, and conformity."

- Aka the space where individuality, growth, and dissent can exist

- Ethics used to focus on humans → Bentham goes from "Can they reason?" to "Can they suffer?"
  - Does ethics have to expand again? Humans → animals → systems that shape human life

Consensus 5: *Expanding "Land Ethic"*

- Chapter 9.2-9.3 shows: small actions → global consequences (pollution, climate change, sustainability)
- Digital ecosystems = new environment
  - Algorithms, surveillance, AI, etc are interconnected like ecological systems
  - Unintended consequences (misinformation, bias, conformity) are like pollution



What's one "digital practice" we treat as normal that (like pollution) creates harmful system-wide effects, even if no single user intends harm?

Constant tracking, personalized recommendation feeds (can maximize engagement), but at a system level they can amplify outrage or misinformation